

The Power of Three

Bhagat's pop treatment of the angst of youth acquires a darker edge



THE 3 MISTAKES OF MY LIFE

by CHETAN BHAGAT

Rupa

Price: Rs 95

Pages: 257

■ By Dilip Bobb

What does one make of Chetan Bhagat? He is an investment banker who writes novels in his spare time and is something of a publishing sensation. His previous two books have made him the biggest-selling Indian novelist writing in English. Yet, he has no intention of giving up his day job. Bhagat writes pop literature targeted at the 20-somethings of India's middle class, using themes that they relate to: jobs, the pressures of work and home, frustrations and ambitions, and, of course, romance.

His writing is amateurish and deliberately Bollywoodian, but calculated and calibrated. His publishers price his books at below Rs 100 to embrace a wider audience and achieve bigger sales. His easy-to-read novels are often based on his background: an IIM-Ahmedabad MBA who met, romanced and married his classmate.

At a subliminal level, Bhagat's books are meant as light, entertaining social commentary on today's young in India's fast-expanding economy. *The 3*

Mistakes of My Life (a pun on it being his third novel) adds a darker edge to his writing and is based on actual events relating to the sectarian riots in Gujarat in 2002. The '3' in his new book revolves around the three issues that Indians, or in this case Gujaratis, obsess over: cricket, religion and business. The plot revolves around three friends struggling to run a business selling cricket equipment and the tragedy that overtakes their lives as they try to protect a young Muslim cricketer they are mentoring. The main protagonist, guilt-ridden at having a secret, torrid affair with his best friend's sister and unable to save their protégé from the mob, attempts suicide, unable to face the three big mistakes in his life.

This is essentially about the generation gap and the differing views on subjects like religion. Set in Ahmedabad and with a small-town ambience, this is Bhagat's attempt to broaden his base by moving away from the urban, elitist flavour of his earlier books. In scope and theme it is certainly a more ambitious venture than his earlier novels. There are sections where his insights into the angst of young Indians are spot on, but Bhagat's patented pop treatment tends to reduce the human tragedy to a Bollywood script. He once admitted that he was a bad writer but a good storyteller. This book is ample proof. ■

Island of Loss

The history of a fictional Tamil family in conflict-torn Sri Lanka



BONE CHINA

by ROMA TEARNE

HarperCollins

Price: Rs 295

Pages: 400

■ By Bunny Suraiya

This novel, starting at the end of 150 years of Crown Rule in Ceylon, spans four generations of de Silvas who, despite their surname, are Tamils, the elite minority favoured by the British over the Sinhalese. From beautiful Grace, who throws herself and her considerable inheritance away on the alcoholic gambler Aloysius de Silva, the thread of family history passes down via her second son Thornton (who flees to England) to his daughter Anna-Meeka and ultimately to her child, Isabella. Along the way, the stories of Thornton's siblings, Alicia the musician, Christopher the cynic and Jacob the bore are told in overmuch detail.

The most interesting aspect of this novel is the retelling of the history of the tragic and ongoing conflict in what is now Sri Lanka; how and when it all began: Sinhalese against Tamil, Christian against Buddhist, high caste against low. The characters are well-delineated; the reader actually worries about their fate, though their repetitious angst slows the pace of the narrative. Too often are we compelled to remember the lost lushness of the island. Too frequent are the descriptions of curfews and child suicide-bombers, of the drunkenness of Aloysius, of the bleakness of England, of the beauty of Grace's precious legacy of bone china....

There are some attractive images and lyrical turns of phrase, but the book would have been greatly improved by tighter editing. So that we would not have farcical dialogue like 'How sweet, you make-a my favourite dish-a!' (from a walk-on Italian 'extra' who makes just this one statement), or infelicitous word usage, as when Grace's lover is seducing her with exquisite slowness, 'as if he was detonating a bomb'. The word should be 'deactivating', surely? ■